

BUAD 4900 Career Development Workbook

Career Competencies, Resume, LinkedIn, and Relocation Planning

Spring 2026

How to use this workbook. Every section here follows a class discussion, not a cold form. The pattern is the same each time: talk it through together on the scheduled Day 2 session, then fill in the page here while the conversation is still fresh. This is one of three workbooks for the course. Interview practice materials are in the Interview Prep Workbook, and the weekly lab report and video reflections are in the Weekly Lab Log. Since this is a fillable PDF, filling a page in directly will overwrite what was there before, so save a new copy before reusing any page that is meant to be filled out more than once. The Career Competencies Self-Assessment is the one exception, since it deliberately holds two points in time in a single file.

AI use policy. Generative AI is welcome for preparation, brainstorming, and polishing throughout this course, with one exception, the practice interviews themselves, covered in the Interview Prep Workbook. The only place it is required is the resume, in the section below.

1 Career Competencies

What this framework is

Every year, the National Association of Colleges and Employers (NACE) surveys employers across industries about what actually separates a job-ready graduate from one who is not. Their answer collapses into eight competencies. This is not a made-up classroom exercise. It is the language career centers, recruiters, and hiring managers across the country actually use, so it is worth understanding well rather than skimming past.

Why rate yourself twice

You will rate yourself honestly in Week 2, before the semester's lab work and interview practice begin, and again in Week 17, during finals week, after a full semester of real lab experience and five practice interviews. The point is not to score well either time. It is to have an honest before-and-after, so growth that might otherwise feel invisible becomes something you can actually see and talk about, including in a future interview.

Career and self-development

Understanding your own strengths and gaps, setting real goals, and building relationships that support your career well beyond this semester. In the lab, this looks like asking for feedback on your code instead of waiting for someone to offer it, and having an actual answer when someone asks what kind of developer role you are aiming for.

Communication

Clearly exchanging ideas, information, and perspectives, and adjusting how you say something depending on who is listening. In the lab, this looks like explaining a bug to a teammate who did not write the code, or writing a status update someone else could understand without you in the room.

Critical thinking

Working through a problem using evidence and reasoning rather than guessing. In the lab, this looks like debugging systematically, forming a hypothesis, testing it, and narrowing things down, instead of changing things at random until something works.

Equity and inclusion

Engaging fairly and respectfully with people whose backgrounds and working styles differ from your own. In the lab, this looks like how you handle a teammate who approaches a problem in a completely different way than you would.

Leadership

Recognizing what you and the people around you are good at, and using that to move something forward, with or without a formal title. In the lab, this looks like picking up a piece of the project nobody assigned to you, or helping a struggling teammate without being asked.

Professionalism

Showing up prepared and reliable, and taking ownership of your work, including your mistakes. In the lab, this looks like logging your hours honestly and giving a heads up before missing a shift instead of just not showing up.

Teamwork

Collaborating well with others, including when you disagree, and sharing both credit and responsibility. In the lab, this looks like disagreeing with a teammate about how to build something without it turning personal.

Technology

Learning and using the right tools for the job, responsibly and efficiently. In the lab, this looks like picking up a new framework or library mid-semester because the project needs it, not because it was assigned.

Self-assessment

Rate yourself honestly in Week 2, right after the class discussion. Do not revisit those ratings. Come back to this same file in Week 17, during finals week, rate yourself again, and add a short note on how each competency actually showed up in the lab or in an interview this semester.

Career and self-development

Week 2

Week 17

Communication

Week 2

Week 17

Critical thinking

Week 2

Week 17

Equity and inclusion

Week 2

Week 17

Leadership

Week 2

Week 17

Professionalism

Week 2

Week 17

Teamwork

Week 2

Week 17

Technology

Week 2

Week 17

Overall growth, Week 17

Looking across all eight, where did you grow the most this semester, and what still needs work

2 Resume Capture Sheet

Fill this out right after the Week 3 resume discussion, while it is still fresh. The conversation is where the real thinking happens; this page is just where it gets written down before you forget it. Once this is filled in, it can be turned into an actual formatted resume document.

What is something you built or did that you are genuinely proud of, even if it does not feel "professional" yet

Contact information

Full name

Phone

Email

City and state

LinkedIn URL

GitHub or portfolio URL

Professional summary

In your own words, from the conversation: who are you and what are you looking for

Education

Institution

Degree and major

Expected graduation

GPA, only if 3.0 or higher (optional)

Technical skills

Languages, frameworks, and tools

Worked example: a stronger bullet

This is the "so what" test from the discussion. Not just what you did, but what happened because you did it.

EXAMPLE — weak: *"Worked on a web application for a class project."*

strong: *"Built a Flask web application with a PostgreSQL backend that let 30 classmates track shared study session times, cutting scheduling emails to near zero."*

The strong version names the tools, says what the thing actually did, and ends with a concrete result. Aim for that shape in the project bullets below.

Project 1

Project name

Tools used

One line description

Key contributions, two to three bullet points worth

Project 2

Project name

Tools used

One line description

Key contributions, two to three bullet points worth

Work or internship experience, if any

Copy this block if there is more than one to list.

Employer

Title

Dates

Achievements

Certifications or awards (optional)

Connecting to lab work

Which lab project or projects this semester could become a resume bullet

Building Your Resume with AI

Opinions on generative AI vary, and that is a reasonable thing to have a position on. This is the one required use of AI in this course. Turning a pile of raw information, your current resume, your projects, your work history, into a clean, well organized document is exactly the kind of task AI genuinely helps with.

Prompt engineering. Before writing a prompt, look up what actually makes one effective; search "prompt engineering" and spend a few minutes reading. In short, a thin prompt makes the AI guess, and guessing produces a generic resume. A thorough prompt loaded with your actual information, your current resume plus everything on this capture sheet, gets a usable draft on the first or second

try instead of the fifth, which is also what keeps the AI efficient rather than wasteful.

Worked example

EXAMPLE — weak prompt: *"Write me a resume."*

strong prompt: *"Here is my current resume [paste it] and here is information from my resume capture sheet [paste your skills, projects, education, and experience]. I am targeting entry level application development roles. Rewrite this as a clean, one page resume, using strong action verbs and quantified results where possible. Flag any section that feels thin so I know what to add."*

A strong prompt includes:

- Your current resume, pasted in full
- Everything from this capture sheet: skills, projects, work experience, certifications
- The type of role you are targeting
- The format you want, for example one page, a specific style
- A request to flag thin or weak spots

After the draft. Read every line. Fix anything that sounds generic, exaggerated, or slightly wrong. An AI draft is a draft, not a finished resume, you are still responsible for every word in it.

The prompt I used

What I had to revise after the first draft

3 LinkedIn Capture Sheet

Fill this out right after the Week 3 LinkedIn discussion. Work directly in LinkedIn while filling this out, and use these fields to draft the wording first.

What is different about how you would describe yourself to a recruiter who finds you online versus a resume you send directly

Worked example: a headline that says more than a job title

EXAMPLE — weak: *"Computer Information Systems Student at State University"*

stronger: *"CIS Student | Building Full-Stack Web Apps | Seeking Junior Developer Roles"*

Custom profile URL (for example [linkedin.com/in/yourname](https://www.linkedin.com/in/yourname))

Headline, more than just a job title

About section draft

Featured section

Resume uploaded to the Featured section

A lab or capstone project linked in the Featured section

A portfolio site or GitHub linked in the Featured section

Links to add

Skills to add

Photo and settings

Uploaded a clear, professional headshot

Added a custom banner image

Set open to work preferences appropriately

Networking goal

One person in my network I could reach out to this month

4 Informational Interview Guide

This is a required piece of career development, assigned in Week 9 and due in Week 12. It has nothing to do with the practice interviews in the Interview Prep Workbook. Nobody is evaluating you here, you are the one asking the questions.

What to wear. Dress business casual for this one, unlike the practice interviews.

What it is

A short, low-stakes conversation with a working professional, not to apply for a job, but to learn about their day-to-day work, how they got into the field, and what they would tell someone just starting out. The person you named as your networking goal on the LinkedIn page is a natural first choice, but anyone in a role you are curious about works.

Why it matters

It gives you real, current information a job posting cannot, it is a low-pressure way to start building a professional network before you actually need one, and it is genuine practice at having a professional conversation, which is its own skill separate from interviewing.

Worked example: asking for the conversation

EXAMPLE — *"Hi Maria, I'm a CIS student at State University interested in learning more about application development in healthcare IT. Would you be willing to talk for twenty minutes about your experience? I would love to hear how you got started and what a typical week looks like. Happy to work around your schedule."*

Keep it short, name a specific amount of time, and make it easy to say yes.

Questions worth asking

About their path: How did you get into this field? What do you wish you had known earlier?

About the day to day: What does a typical week look like? What is the most challenging part of the job?

About the field: What is changing in this industry right now? What skills are becoming more important?

Advice: What would you tell someone just starting out? Is there anyone else you would recommend I talk to?

One thing to avoid: do not ask directly for a job during this conversation. That changes what the meeting is for, and most people can tell.

After the conversation

Send a thank you note within a day or two. It does not need to be long, just specific about what you found useful.

Who I am interviewing, name and role

Date

Questions I plan to ask (pick three or four from above, or write your own)

What I learned

One way this changed how I am thinking about my own path

5 Relocation Plan Capture Sheet

Fill this out right after the Week 14 relocation discussion. CareerOneStop, a U.S. Department of Labor sponsored site, has free cost of living and salary comparison tools worth starting with, at [careeronestop.org](https://www.careeronestop.org). Fill in one target location below. If a second location is genuinely under consideration, copy the target location block for a second comparison.

Before any research: where have you thought about living after graduation, and why

Current baseline

Current city and state

Current approximate monthly cost of living (rent, utilities, general expenses)

Target location

City and state

Why this location

EXAMPLE — vague: *"There are probably tech jobs there."*

specific: *"Three mid-size fintech companies and a regional hospital system's IT department are hiring application developers here, based on a quick search of their careers pages."*

Job market notes (companies hiring in this field here, typical roles available)

Estimated salary range for this role here

Cost of living comparison versus current city

Housing notes (neighborhoods, typical rent, commute considerations)

Professional community (local meetups, alumni contacts, LinkedIn connections here)

Moving logistics and budget

Estimated moving costs

Notice needed at current lease or housing

Target moving timeline

Other logistics (license, voter registration, and similar)

Decision summary

Which location am I leaning toward, and why